



Common App Bootcamp: Jumpstarting Your College Application Process



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This edition is designed to be viewed on-screen to save trees.

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Introduction

Welcome to the Collegewise Common App Bootcamp! In choosing to enroll, you've taken one meaningful step towards making your college application process more sane and manageable.

Applying to college is an exciting but often overwhelming period for families. How do admission officers evaluate activities? What makes an essay stand out? What role does the interview play in the application process?

We've got you covered.

Our counseling experts will teach you about the fundamentals of college applications, how to build a smart college list, and how to distinguish your application. You'll learn how to map out an application timeline from start to finish with a clear checklist. And, above all, we hope you'll finish this course having learned more about yourself. When you enroll in college next fall, we don't just want you to be excited to arrive on campus; we want you to feel more prepared, confident, and self-assured as you embark on the next chapter of your life.

That's a lot to tackle! So, let's get started.

Course Syllabus

1. College Essays

- Read and critique sample personal statements
- Choose your personal statement topic
- Learn how to make your essays stand out
- Revise and improve your personal statement
- Review common supplemental essay prompts

3. Develop the Five Elements of Your College Application

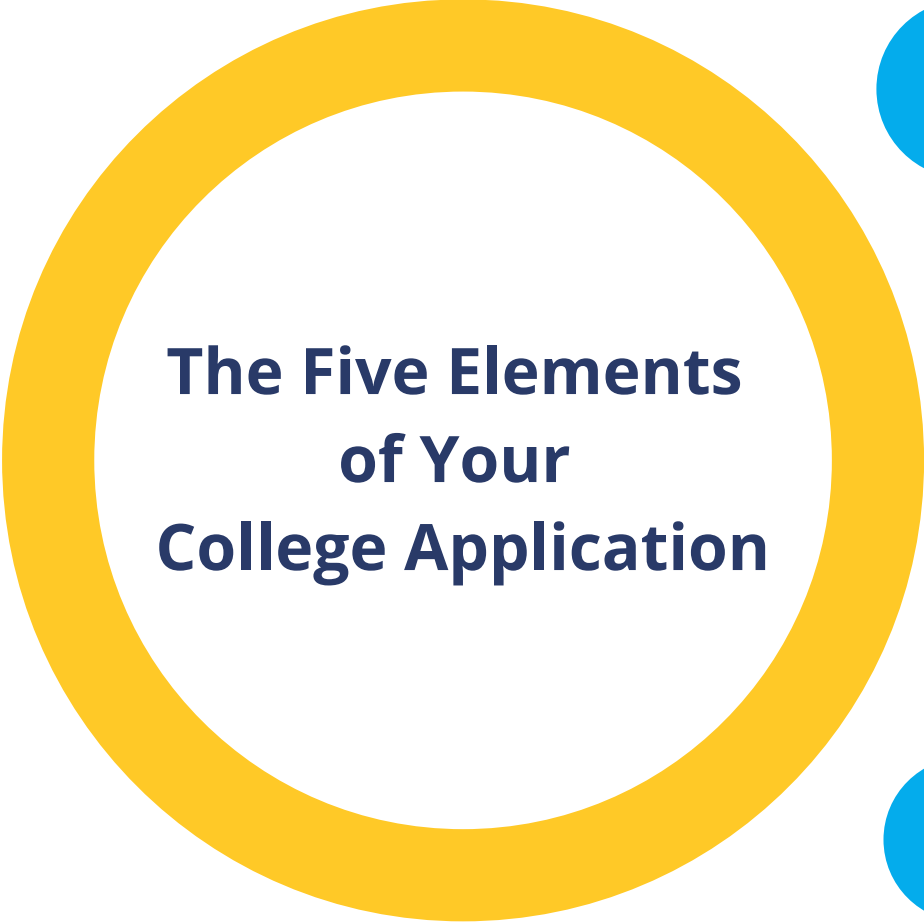
- Understand transcripts
- Contemplate letters of recommendation
- Develop and enhance activity list
- Understand the implications of your testing record
- Complete the Common Application

2. Understanding Admissions and the College Search

- Learn the best ways to investigate potential schools
- Search for schools and create a realistic college list
- Discuss best practices while visiting colleges

4. Interviews and Activities

- Analyze potential types of questions to expect in interviews
- Practice and observe interviews with peers
- Learn how to develop a thorough and organized activity list



The Five Elements of Your College Application

01.

Academic Record: Transcript
Rigor, consistency, and how you used the curriculum offered

02.

Testing Record
SAT, ACT, and AP exam scores

03.

Support File
Letters of recommendation and interviews

04.

Activity List
Extracurricular activities, honors/awards, and hobbies/interests.

05.

Essays
Personal statement and supplements

1. High School Academic Record

Grade Point Average

Total GPA, Weighted

Academic GPA, Weighted

Total GPA, Unweighted

Academic GPA, Unweighted

Senior Year Courses

While many of the schools you apply to won't see your senior year grades before they render an admission decision, they will see your senior year course schedule. On your application, you'll need to note which courses are AP, IB, Honors, etc. As a general rule, you want to maintain or increase rigor from junior to senior year.

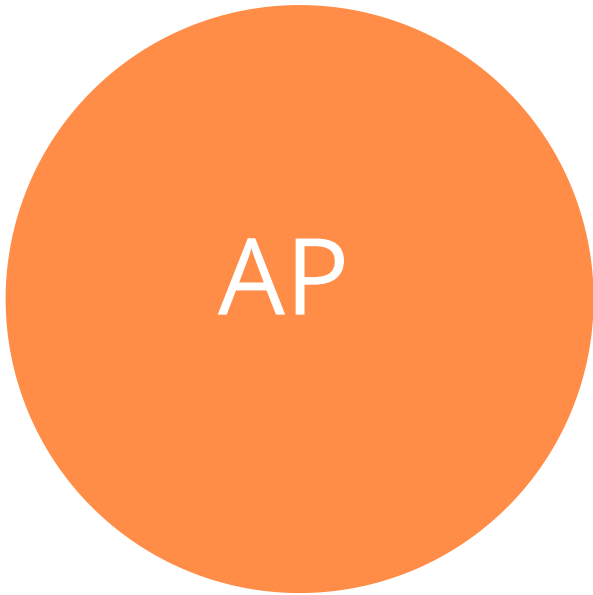
2. Standardized Test Scores



SAT



ACT



AP

You'll need to indicate any planned tests for which you will not have results by the time you submit your application. If you are taking an AP course senior year, you should plan to and indicate that you will take the AP exam in the spring.

3. Extracurricular Activities

If you had the chance to have a ten-minute conversation with an admissions officer to explain everything you do that is important to you, what would you talk about? How would you sum up the way you've spent your life in high school when you weren't in class?

You probably wouldn't start with, "One time, I went to a meeting of the Spanish Club!" It wouldn't make sense to talk first about an activity that you didn't care that much about or didn't spend much time doing. Instead, you'd probably begin by discussing your most important activities—the ones on which you spent significant time and energy.

However, you'd be surprised how many students list their activities in no particular order when filling out college applications. Listing an activity first that meant little to you is like telling an admissions officer that the one week you attended a meeting of the "Ping Pong Club" was the most important thing you did in high school.

You're probably not going to get the chance to have that conversation with an admissions officer, but you can use your application to help admissions officers not only get a clear sense of how you spent your time outside of class, but also which activities helped define your high school experience.

One last thing: The applicant with the longest list of activities is not necessarily the one who's going to get in. Admissions officers are looking for 2-4 significant ways you spent your time outside of class. If you list 50 activities, you're just making it harder for them to figure out what your 2-4 most significant ones were.

4. Letters of Recommendation

Q

What role do letters of recommendation play in the application process?

A

Letters of recommendation give insight into who you are as a student from someone who knows you well and may echo things you've already shared and/or add new information to your application.

Q

How many letters of recommendation do I need in order to apply to college?

A

Each college has different guidelines on how many letters are required and how many additional letters you can send, so make sure to check the college websites to confirm each school's requirements. As a general rule, you should plan to ask your school counselor and two teachers for letters of recommendation.

Q

Who should I ask to write me a letter of recommendation?

A

- Try to ask teachers from core subject areas (math, science, English, social science, and languages other than English). Because they're core classes with a standardized academic curriculum, your admissions officer will be able to contextualize your achievements and consider your potential as a college student more easily.
- Try to ask 11th grade teachers. You'll be applying to college during the fall and early winter of 12th grade. At that point, your 12th grade teachers will have only known you for a couple of months; that's usually not enough to have an in-depth picture of who you are. At the same time, your 10th grade teachers will have gone nearly two years without you in their classroom; the things they can write about may not reflect who you are as that's way too long for an accurate letter for a senior. So, stick to your 11th grade teachers in most circumstances.
- Make sure to align your recommenders with the expectations of the colleges you're applying to. For instance, some require one letter from a STEM teacher and one letter from a humanities teacher.
- Don't worry too much about your teachers' writing abilities. It's the content, not the style, that's important.

5. Essay Topics

Why do Colleges Require Essays?



What better way to get to know students than through their own words? Most colleges practice holistic admissions, meaning that there are multiple factors being considered in the admissions decision. Schools that practice holistic admissions are not plotting GPAs and test scores on a spreadsheet to determine if a student meets the bar to be admitted or not. (For some schools with formulaic admissions, it really is as simple as earning a certain GPA or GPA-and-test-score combination to determine if you're admissible. And to be fair, many schools that practice holistic admissions may not require essays.) Instead, admissions readers look at many factors outside of just the transcript and test scores to get to know you (the student) better. This is done through activities, recommendation letters, and essays.

The essays, specifically, give students an opportunity to add context to their application, share more of their personality, and also highlight why they'd be a great fit for the college (and vice versa).

College Application Checklist

1

Personal Statement

- ☐ Rough Draft
- ☐ Self-Assessment
- ☐ Review by Editor
- ☐ Incorporation of Feedback
- ☐ **Completed Essay**

2

Activity List

- ☐ Include All Activities
- ☐ Review by Counselor
- ☐ Incorporation of Feedback
- ☐ **Completed Activity Summary**

3

College List

- ☐ Include at least 6 schools
- ☐ Categorize schools as RTL
- ☐ Locate middle 50%

4

Completed Common App

5

Five Major Elements

Building a Balanced List

As a general rule, we recommend students apply to 8 to 12 colleges.

Likely

These are schools where you're very likely to be accepted. Your SAT/ACT and GPA are higher than the average student accepted.

Reach

These are schools where the likelihood of admission is slim. Your SAT/ACT and GPA are lower than those of the average student accepted AND/OR the acceptance rate is below 20%.



Target

These are schools where there is moderate probability you'll be accepted. Your SAT/ACT and GPA match those of the average students accepted AND the acceptance rate is NOT below 20%.

***ALL schools on your list should be schools you would be happy to attend, regardless of RTL categorization.**

Senior Year Application Timeline

August through September



Common App refreshes August 1st



Register for fall SAT/ACT administration and remember to plan it around sporting events, clubs, etc



Schedule a meeting with your counselor to discuss your transcript, testing scores, college choices, and letters of recommendation.

Pro Tip: Be sure to submit transcripts for Early Decision and Early Action Schools



Create a list of application deadlines

Pro Tip: Start this as early as possible — some schools have October deadlines



Read up on the colleges that you are interested in and develop a list of intelligent questions to ask college representatives when they visit



Contact additional teachers from whom you will request recommendations and ask them if they can write on your behalf; give them a copy of your résumé



Research scholarship opportunities through websites such as www.fastweb.com and www.finaid.org

Senior Year Application Timeline

October



- ✓ Be mindful of October application deadlines
- ✓ Keep up your grades and continue to visit schools
- ✓ Attend college nights and admissions fairs at your high school
- ✓ Check in with teachers who are writing your letters of recommendation to see if they need any additional information from you
- ✓ Confirm transcript requests with your counselor
- ✓ Continue to research scholarship opportunities
- ✓ Begin FAFSA forms for financial aid (<https://fafsa.ed.gov/>)
- ✓ Begin CSS forms for financial aid (<https://cssporfile.collegeboard.org>)

Senior Year Application Timeline

November



- ✓ Most Early Action and Early Decision deadlines will be in November
- ✓ Many other colleges have Regular Decision deadlines in November, including University of Washington and the University of California system
- ✓ Make sure to thoroughly complete your applications in advance of the deadlines and leave time to proofread the full application prior to submission



Receiving admission decisions isn't the only occasion to celebrate during the application process. Pause to celebrate when you submit your applications. This moment is the culmination of the effort you put into the actual application AND all of the hard work you've put in over the past 3+ years!

Senior Year Application Timeline

December through January



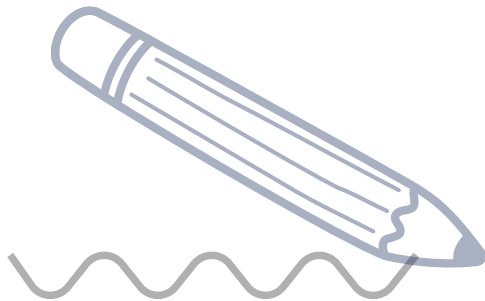
Remember to give teachers and counselors at least two weeks to process your application and/or recommendations



Submit all transcript request forms with a January 1st deadline AT LEAST two weeks before Winter Break



Remember, college admission acceptances are conditional based on grades. You should earn the same (or better) grades as in the first semester because a university reserves the right to rescind an admission if a student's grades drop



Pro Tip: Aim to finish your applications *before* winter break so you can enjoy the time off from school.

Senior Year Application Timeline

February through May



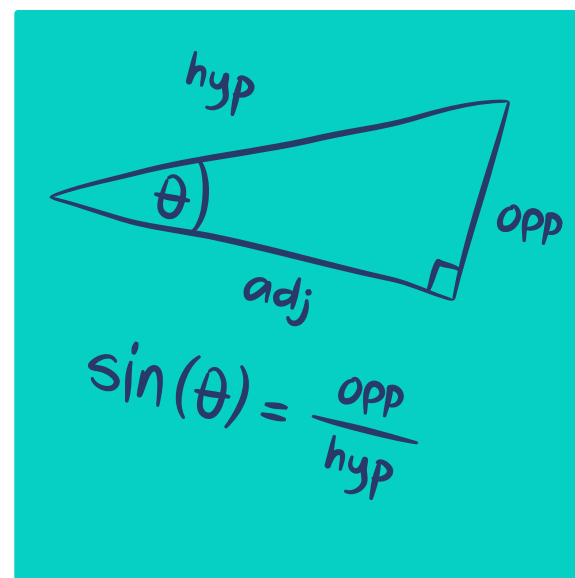
- ✓ Submit completed financial aid forms no later than February
- ✓ Continue to keep your grades up
- ✓ Be sure to submit a mid-year report to all schools that require it
- ✓ Universities will notify students of acceptances through April 15th
- ✓ Notify schools by May 1st of your intent to enroll and pay deposit
- ✓ Withdraw your name from other colleges still in consideration
- ✓ Inform your counselor about each admission and financial aid award
- ✓ For athletes, request a final transcript to be sent to the NCAA Eligibility Center
- ✓ Register to attend on-campus orientation/registration programs that will occur over the summer
- ✓ Thank your parents, teachers, and counselors for their support!

The Role of the Personal Statement

Over 1,000 colleges and universities across the world utilize the [Common App](#) application platform, meaning there's a very good chance students will encounter the 650-word Personal Statement. The Personal Statement is an essay that every college a student applies to on Common App will review. For that reason, students want to make sure that their Personal Statement is not specific to any one college. This essay should be universal enough that it doesn't matter which school is reading it.

Many students can feel a lot of pressure to come up with the “right” essay topic.

The truth is that there is no secret formula for the essay; there is no one specific thing a college is looking for. They just want to get to know you better — it really is as simple as that!



What the Personal Statement Could Be About

01. A large-scale, defining moment in life
02. A small, memorable situation
03. A hobby, job, or summer experience
04. Or anything else in between that matters to the student



Personal Statement: Dos and Don'ts



Answer the question(s)

It sounds intuitive, but we always tell students to make sure they're answering the question(s) at hand. The Common App gives students seven essay prompts to respond to (six questions and one open-ended "topic of your choice"). Admissions officers don't care which question is chosen, but they do care that the answer is addressing the specific question (or questions) being asked.



Keep it personal

This essay is called a "personal statement" for a reason— it needs to be personal to the student! Whether the student is writing about a role model or life experience, it's important to bring the story back to the author. The student is the person the admission reader wants to get to know most.



Use your own voice

It's always a good idea to have someone else look over an essay to catch lingering spelling or grammar errors. (Proofreading is important!) But during the writing process, students want to make sure there's only one cook in the kitchen, so to speak. Admissions officers who have read thousands of essays are pretty good at being able to tell when an essay has been written by an adult or someone else. Don't stress too much about having to sound overly polished, and don't go nuts with the thesaurus. The essay should sound like it was written by a 17-year-old—because it was!

Personal Statement: Dos and Don'ts



Try to impress the reader

Many students feel pressure to come up with a Personal Statement that is going to “wow” the admissions reader, something that is going to put them over the edge to be admitted. The admission officer will read about big accomplishments in other parts of the application; the essay is where students can show a deeper side of who they are. The essay is not a competition to determine which student has overcome the most challenging obstacle or who has earned the highest award. It's about the smaller moments and experiences. So instead, students should focus on writing an essay they are proud of and a story they want to share most.



Be repetitive

Students have a finite amount of space to share their narrative. And an admissions reader has a finite amount of time to read the application—mere minutes. The Personal Statement should be looked at as a vehicle to share new, different information that isn't present in the rest of the application. Using the limited amount of space in the essay to repeat information is not what the essay is for!



Try to summarize your entire life

Students, this one is specifically for you. 650 words isn't a lot, and if you try to manufacture a story that encapsulates all of your interests, passions, motivations, and ambitions, you'll quickly realize that you just don't have enough space. Resist the temptation to summarize your entire life story in this essay. Instead, narrow the scope of this essay to focus on a smaller moment or experience that reflects something important about you.

The 7 Bes of the College Essay

Be concise: The Common Application limits essays to 650 words, which isn't too much at all for such an important essay. Admissions officers read hundreds of essays during the "busy season", so it's important that you say all you want to say, while making it a quick and enjoyable read within the word limit.

Be honest: Do not embellish your accomplishments in the essay, or anywhere else on the college application for that matter. Be proud of the clubs you are a part of, the awards you have received, the experiences you have encountered, even if they do not seem to be the most elaborate.

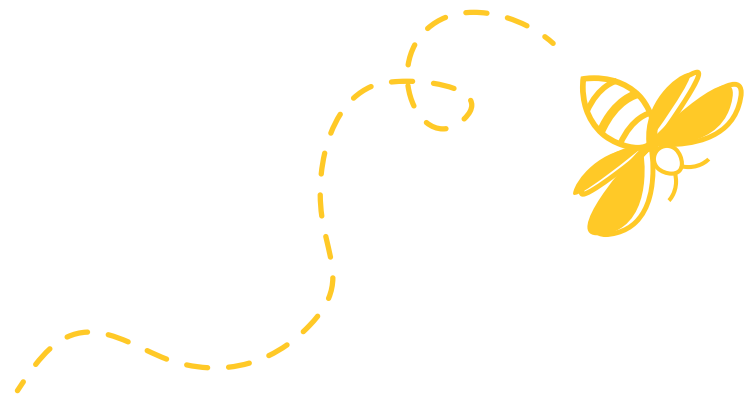
Be coherent: The most difficult part of the essay may be picking one topic to write about. Try not to cover your entire life in one essay, and just focus on one part. As your story starts to wander, so will the minds of counselors. Be confident in the topic you have chosen and stick with it throughout the essay.

Be grammatically correct: If you are just relying on the spell check feature on your computer, you may be in trouble. Make sure you have multiple people proofread your essay to make sure the grammar and structure of the essay are all flawless. If possible, it is a great idea to have an English teacher proofread the essay to give the final approval.

Be detailed: This essay should read as a story and needs to keep the interest of the reader from beginning to end. Make your story come to life by adding specific details and information to what you are talking about.

Be different: As mentioned, it is imperative to be honest and accurate in your essay, but take time to reflect and think of a topic that will be different from your peers. Pick something that only you can talk about.

Be yourself: If you have a great sense of humor, let this show in the essay. If you are more of a serious person, that's okay too! You put yourself in a bad place when you try to alter your personality to make the essay sound "better". You certainly want to put your best foot forward and you want your essay to shine, but there is nothing better than being yourself, and this will shine above all else.



Essay Topics to Avoid



Being the Hero

Talking about a great accomplishment can lead to a compelling essay, but not if you're clearly trying to brag. Writing an essay where you single-handedly won the state championship basketball game could inadvertently reflect poor collaboration skills. But an essay where you worked with your teammates to overcome a significant point gap? That demonstrates an accomplishment AND positive qualities about your character.



Woe is Me

Your personal statement should give insight into who you are. Perhaps that includes discussing a failure, struggle, or obstacle. But avoid spending too much time discussing how hard the situation was for you and spend more time on how you surmounted the problem and grew from the experience.



The Travel Channel

While adventures can be great topics for an essay, you want to avoid relaying every detail of the trip as though you were writing a travel blog. While we're certain the activities were fun, the admissions counselors want to learn more about the most notable parts of your trip and the experience's impact on you.

Essay Topics to Avoid



Stand-up Comedy

Your essay should sound like you, and if you're a funny person, you can infuse humor into your essay. But be wary of sprinkling jokes into the content — you don't want to include so many that you turn the content into a nonstop parade of jokes.



Excuses

Don't use your personal statement to explain why mistakes you made in school weren't really your fault. Admissions readers don't expect you to be perfect, and it could draw more negative attention to your mistake if you try to pass it off as someone else's fault.



List of Accomplishments

Anything that can be found elsewhere in your college application, especially in the 'Activities' or résumé portion, should not be the focus of your college essay. Admissions readers don't want to read another list of your accomplishments. Your personal statement should tell them a compelling story that will give insight into who you are as a person.



Have you ever fallen in love with a reality that is not quite reality? Have you ever been enchanted by language beautifully crafted, language that sets your soul on fire and changes your perspective on life forever? If you have, then you must share my love of language, my love of books and literature. I truly revel in reading books and poetry; when I read I feel content and at home in a world of language and knowledge.

I read as much as possible. At every free moment I usually have my head buried in a novel, textbook, poem, or whatever magazine or piece of writing I can get my hands on. My favorite store is Barnes & Noble and my Kindle e-reader is one of my most valuable possessions. Reading is my safe haven and my escape. Through books I discover new people and strange universes; I learn what it is like to be a completely different creature. I am only satisfied when I discover new things and ideas because I am always in pursuit of knowledge. I enjoy the new knowledge that comes from reading but I also admire great stories and remarkable writing because it allows me to see and appreciate different ways of thinking, others' perspectives, and others' lives. Reading literature inspires me and transforms me like nothing else on Earth. Henry David Thoreau stated in *Walden*, "How many a man has dated a new era in his life from the reading of a book." Thoreau understood even then the way books alter and affect me today. Writing is a magnificent and powerful thing that has an enormous impact on my life and way of thinking. Great books and poetry leave me in total awe afterwards; I still spend time weeks and years later thinking about that work and more often than not it changes my perspective on life permanently.

Some of my best and fondest memories of my childhood involve reading. I remember I first fell in love with books when my dad began to read the Harry Potter Series to my siblings and me every night when we were just four years old. Bedtime usually was not most kids' favorite part of the day, but it was mine. I could not wait to listen to my dad read and get lost in the world of Harry Potter. I also treasured the scholastic book fair my grammar school had once a year. Each year I would beg my mom to buy as many books as possible. I would spend hours after school at the fair reading the backs of the books and choosing my favorites. I even began staying up late at night under the covers with a flashlight reading. After my dad stopped reading to us I still kept reading before bed. To this day I cannot go to sleep without first reading a couple chapters of a book. Reading has always been a gigantic part of my life from the time I was little. Literature influenced me as a child and still influences me greatly to this day.

Reading is self-teaching; reading even comics or goofy romance books can be a learning experience. Books act as teachers, inspirations, and they affect people emotionally and philosophically. My goal is to one day be compared to a really incredible book. I hope I meet people, inspire them, and change them for the better as books do for me. Through my life I have worked and I am still working to become a great book; I hope I grow to become a story that people I meet will never forget.



"Live from New York, it's Saturday Night!" My sister couldn't breathe. I sat in the back of an ambulance with her, as she trusted me to stay calm. We pulled up to the emergency room, moving her into the building on a stretcher on a late Saturday night. I couldn't think. I felt like I couldn't breathe, even though my sister was the one having the reaction. My anxiety was bursting through the roof.

Sitting in the hospital room, being with my sisters (who were both fine) and mom, we turned on the television. We needed to lighten the mood, having been in the hospital for a while. "Live from New York, it's Saturday Night!" It wasn't the best environment you could imagine, but my mother was letting me watch this show for the first time. However, we could only watch Saturday Night Live under one condition. If anything became too vulgar, my mother would turn off the television. I had never seen the show before (only heard about it), so I was entirely compliant. I was mesmerized, and it had become one of the first things I had ever watched on television that made me physically laugh. Owing to my mother's stipulation, we watched less than half of the show, but I knew I needed to see more.

That week, I became captivated by SNL, and the following Saturday I wanted to watch the new episode. Again, my mother would watch it with me and turn off anything not appropriate. This cycle became a normal occurrence, and I would watch whatever parts of the show that I could every weekend. I became immersed in the show, its cast members, and what they did to get ready for the show each weekend. It intrigued me and I wanted to watch everything that they came up with for each live show. It made me even more interested than I already was in the performing arts. I wanted to be up there with the cast, making people laugh. I looked forward to watching "Weekend Update" every week. I thought watching the news on a daily basis was boring, but when I watched that segment, I wanted to keep up with all news outlets so that I could follow along with the jokes that Seth Meyers made on the air.

Finally, one Saturday night came along, and my mother told me that she trusted me enough to watch the show by myself and be mature about it. You would not believe my reaction—I was thrilled beyond description. I felt like she was finally treating me like an adult. After the longest time of subjecting me to her rules, my mother was letting me make my own wise choices. I knew she was trusting me with much more than watching the program that I had grown to love. She was granting me freedom to choose what was right for me. That moment was not just about a show on television. It was about having the liberation of making my own choices. This trust also came with responsibility. I realized that now I need to be the adult that I am when making choices, and choose things that will impact my life, and others, positively. Whether it be watching a television show, or choosing a career path, I felt like my choices were valid, and my mother would trust me to make the right ones. It was a feeling unlike any other, sitting in front of the television alone at 11:30 p.m. "Live from New York, it's Saturday night!"

Brainstorming Part 1

Respond to 4 of the 7 questions below (pick whatever feels easiest to write about). Try your best to apply the lessons you've learned in the brainstorming videos and from your workshop instructor. Be yourself and infuse plenty of specific details so you can really own your story (e.g., striped hair follicles!). Please aim for at least one long paragraph for each of your 4 responses.

- 1 What have been the three most important parts of your high school experience?
- 2 What's something you could talk about for hours?
- 3 In what ways do you think your community (family, friends, geography, ethnicity, activity) has shaped you?
- 4 Think of a moment when you felt most yourself. What were you doing?
- 5 Quirks can help differentiate us. What's one of yours? (shout-out to Occidental College for the inspiration for this one!)
- 6 There was you, then THIS happened, and then there was different-you. Describe THIS (i.e., what was a major turning point in your life?).
- 7 What have you done to make your school, community, family, or friend group better this past year? What inspired you to act?

Brainstorming Part 2

Answer the following quick takes with brief phrases or sentences.

1 A thing people are always surprised to learn about me:

2 I'm the kind of person who:

3 The five words that best describe me are:

4 One thing I'd like to be better at is:

5 I feel most myself when I'm with/at/in:

6 Fictional character I feel most similar to:

7 Something I could teach anyone in 5 minutes:

8 I'm obsessed with:

9 My (actual) superpower is:

10 I'm inspired by:

Free Write Activity

Using one of your answers as a jumping off point, write 2 to 3 paragraphs, using the lessons of sharing something brand new and remembering to sound like you. Don't worry too much about grammar - just focus on exploration and discovery. Trust the process and follow your instincts!

Common App Prompts

- 1** Some students have a background, identity, interest, or talent that is so meaningful they believe their application would be incomplete without it. If this sounds like you, then please share your story.
- 2** The lessons we take from obstacles we encounter can be fundamental to later success. Recount a time when you faced a challenge, setback, or failure. How did it affect you, and what did you learn from the experience?
- 3** Reflect on a time when you questioned or challenged a belief or idea. What prompted your thinking? What was the outcome?
- 4** Reflect on something that someone has done for you that has made you happy or thankful in a surprising way. How has this gratitude affected or motivated you?
- 5** Discuss an accomplishment, event, or realization that sparked a period of personal growth and a new understanding of yourself or others.
- 6** Describe a topic, idea, or concept you find so engaging that it makes you lose all track of time. Why does it captivate you? What or who do you turn to when you want to learn more?
- 7** Share an essay on any topic of your choice. It can be one you've already written, one that responds to a different prompt, or one of your own design.

College Essay Potential Topics

It's time to write down potential essay topics. Utilize the lessons you've learned from the college essay samples and the insights you've gathered from your brainstorming exercises. You will need to write down **10 possible topics**.



Once you've selected your topic, **draft your opening line**. Feel free to write down a few to give yourself options. Then, select the sentence you feel best grabs your reader's attention and appropriately sets the tone for the topic and content of your essay.

Essay Analysis

For the following exercise, we'll deconstruct some sample essays to identify what is and isn't working well in each essay. Please keep the following questions in mind as you read:

- 1 Does this essay answer the prompt?
- 2 Do you get a sense of the author's voice and personality?
- 3 Do you believe the author is authentic?
- 4 Is there anything you would change about this essay? Any major critiques of this essay?
- 5 What are your favorite and least favorite parts of this essay?
- 6 If this is a student on the border of being accepted and you were the admissions officer, would this essay make you want to extend an offer of admission to the student or deny them an offer of admission?



Prompt: Some students have a background, identity, interest, or talent that is so meaningful they believe their application would be incomplete without it. If this sounds like you, then please share your story.

When I introduce myself to people, I say that my species is facing extinction. No, I am not a leatherback sea turtle, however, I am affectionately known as a “redhead,” or a “ginger” to others. With headlines, however accurate they may be, circulating that redheads are going the way of the black rhino, I pause to reflect on what my strawberry blond locks mean. However frivolous it may seem, I’ve found that my hair has had a profound impact on my life.

The first thing one notices about a “ginger” is - surely enough - the red hair. Speaking from experience, I have found it nearly impossible to blend in with a crowd. Whether it be at school, at a local eatery in town, or commuting via NJ Transit to school, it feels like I am always in the spotlight. Being the youngest of a well-known family in my town adds to this sensation of being under a microscope. It can be exhausting and often stressful to feel like I am always being watched. Ultimately, I think the fact that I have red hair has given me a genuine sense of responsibility and has helped me mature quickly. I know it may sound ridiculous that my hair color could influence my responsibility and maturity levels, but I think it has merit.

Ever since 5th grade, when I started hanging out “downtown” with my friends, I have always felt that some people would probably spot the red hair, recognize me, and think, “there’s that O’Brien kid.” Who knows if that actually transpires - maybe I’m just flattering myself - but I can’t help but think that my theory reflects some element of reality. As a result, I have adopted the old rule of thumb: “Make each decision as if your mother was watching.” And I have my red hair to thank for that. Because my red hair attracts onlookers’ eyes, I have trained myself to approach every decision with a certain element of discernment. Whether it be a decision as significant as who I hang out with, or one as incidental as holding a door for people in public, I find that I am very conscientious of my actions. Maybe that’s part of my persona, but I like to place a good deal of responsibility on the eye-grabber that is my “redheadedness.”

Essay Sample #1

Another lesson my red hair has taught me is the value - or lack thereof - in physical appearance. I've heard my fair share of name-calling and teasing directed at my hair. While none of it brought me to tears, often I became frustrated and discouraged. Remembering my own emotions, I empathize with others who suffer from far worse and more offensive bullying based solely on external appearance. I remember how comforting it felt to hear from a friend or acquaintance that my hair was cool or "cute." Now, I try to extend a compliment to those I encounter, whether it be their hairstyle, their glasses, or my personal favorite, their socks. It's a small thing, but it gave me self-assurance. Maybe it can help somebody else too.

Sure, I've been affected by name-calling. Of course I've wished that I could be blond or brown-haired, just to be a "normal kid." But I'm beginning to realize that my striking "redheadedness" coincides with my vocation as a leader. I've come to accept that because of my hair, it's nearly impossible to stay out of the spotlight. I've embraced it. Now, I look at my red hair as an opportunity to be a beacon of everything my Jesuit high school wants out of its students - service to others, intellectual competence, commitment to justice, and openness to growth. My grandfather used to say, "God bless that red hair." Now I've come to understand what exactly he meant.

Discussion Q's

Does this essay answer the prompt?

Do you get a sense of the author's voice and personality?

Do you believe the author is authentic?

Is there anything you would change about this essay? Any major critiques of this essay?

What are your favorite and least favorite parts of this essay?

If this is a student on the border of being accepted and you were the admissions officer, would this essay make you want to extend an offer of admission to the student or deny them an offer of admission?



Prompt: The lessons we take from obstacles we encounter can be fundamental to later success. Recount a time when you faced a challenge, setback, or failure. How did it affect you, and what did you learn from the experience?

The sport I love the most almost ruined my athletic career and my confidence altogether. Soccer has played a large role in my life from fourth grade to now. Having asthma makes it a little difficult to keep up with the other players, but that just means that I have to push myself harder. Even though I dreaded going to practice, I'd bite the bullet, lace up and head out onto the field. I played sweeper and won best defensemen in the league in eighth grade. My coach, parents, and friends all thought it would be easy for me to make my high school team, and so did I.

August 19th I went for my first day of tryouts. I was a little nervous, but still confident that making the team would be easy. After the first week I was tired and sore, but happy that I made first cuts. Three days later, still on the brink of exhaustion, I made second cuts. I was excited as I only had two more days of tryouts left and then I was on the team. The two days of tryouts past, and on the last day the coach called all the candidates for the J.V. team over. He started to read the names of the five kids that needed to be cut from the team. After two names were called, I then heard my name and my heart sank. I quickly looked up to see if he had made a mistake. Certainly he must have read the wrong name. How could he cut me from the team when I was so close to making it? The coach finished the names and told everyone that it was a good tryout and told everyone to head home. Devastated, upset, and enraged I got into my car and headed home.

During the ride home my mind raced with thoughts. What did I do wrong? Why did he say my name? Finally, I thought I wasn't good enough. Right then and there I decided that I was going to give up on sports. Even though I joined my school's drill team, I felt incomplete without playing soccer. I decided to train and tryout again for soccer. I would be older, stronger and better. Sophomore year came and I tried out again, but didn't have the same confidence as freshman year and it showed through my playing. I made it through first cuts, but was quickly cut right after. I was convinced that I shouldn't try out for anything because it would just lead to failure.

Essay Sample #2

My parents both saw that I was upset that I couldn't play soccer, so they told me to keep my head up and keep on trying. I thought to myself and decided that my high school's soccer team isn't the only one out there. I started to look for a local soccer club in my community and found the Jaguars. I called the coach and told him I was interested in trying out. I went to the tryouts and made the team. I was excited and happy. Once again soccer was in my life. A few months after playing with the Jaguars, another coach came to me and asked me if I would play for his team. Of course I said yes and was thrilled that I tried out for this club team or I would have never had this opportunity.

I decided that for the rest of my high school career and my future that I would be open to trying new things. Even if I fail or don't succeed it wouldn't be the worst thing in the world. I believe that failure is my best teacher. It makes me think and try harder than I did before.

Discussion Q's

Does this essay answer the prompt?

Do you get a sense of the author's voice and personality?

Do you believe the author is authentic?

Is there anything you would change about this essay? Any major critiques of this essay?

What are your favorite and least favorite parts of this essay?

If this is a student on the border of being accepted and you were the admissions officer, would this essay make you want to extend an offer of admission to the student or deny them an offer of admission?



Prompt: Reflect on a time when you questioned or challenged a belief or idea. What prompted your thinking? What was the outcome?

Like anyone, I've had days where I get home from school and have just had enough. Maybe a long night of trig and 19th century U.S. history awaits me, or possibly a muscle cramps up when it is time for a run, or (more often than not), I'm just a little low on sleep. We all get over these days, though. You grab a coffee, or grab your phone to call a friend, depending on what the situation requires, you manage to get through the day, and you move past it. However, one day of my junior year had a far more profound effect than the typical "bad day."

My high school - in accordance with its Jesuit identity - encourages its students to explore the theme of social justice, manifested by the mandatory course entitled "Christian Ethics," designed to analyze contemporary issues such as gender and race roles in society. That class has largely succeeded in its mission to initiate conversations about the aforementioned social issues. Thus, in the wake of the death and court ruling of Michael Brown, the young man killed by Ferguson Police Officer Darren Wilson, students discussed feelings, thoughts, and emotions in response to these events. Conversations of these sorts seemed to be so ubiquitous that the student council organized an open mic event to serve as a safe place for students to speak their minds.

Coming into the event, I had not formed much of an opinion on the court ruling of the Michael Brown events. In my typical fashion, I listened to opinions of all varieties before making my own judgment. Roughly 30 minutes into the conversation, I began to understand the complexity of the issue and started to flesh out my own opinion. I decided that I would go up to the mic and share my thoughts. However, as soon as I made that decision, the event came to a close, and I was left feeling frustrated not to take the opportunity to share my opinion.

Essay Sample #3

Of course there is an element of disappointment when you don't get your thoughts across, but this situation stung in particular because of the nature of the issue. It was my first opportunity to engage in a real formal discussion of things bigger than my own world. Would my words have inspired all those listening to undergo a transformation of thought in their own minds? Certainly not; I would be foolish to think so. But perhaps some people would have seen merit in my thoughts. That is when true progress becomes attainable - when people bounce ideas off each other and collaborate. Issues of this mold are too complex and too overpowering to handle individually. And that is why this is such a lasting regret of mine. My ideas - regardless of their viability - are worthless unless I share them. From that day I have taken the opinion that it is a disservice to the community not to share your informed, educated opinion.

Discussion Q's

Does this essay answer the prompt?

Do you get a sense of the author's voice and personality?

Do you believe the author is authentic?

Is there anything you would change about this essay? Any major critiques of this essay?

What are your favorite and least favorite parts of this essay?

If this is a student on the border of being accepted and you were the admissions officer, would this essay make you want to extend an offer of admission to the student or deny them an offer of admission?

Activity List

Q

Does the Common App require a résumé?

A

The Common App does not include a section for a résumé, but it does include two sections where you can describe your activities and awards: the Activities section and the Education Honors section.

Q

How many activities and awards can you share?

A

The Activities section will allow for up to 10 activities and the Education Honors section will allow for up to 5 academic honors and awards.

Activity List

Section I: Activities

The most important thing you should do in this section is to arrange your activities in order of most important to least important. Your most important activity will likely be one in which you spent significant time and enjoyed some degree of success.

For each activity, list:

1. The name of the activity (soccer, ASB, school newspaper, etc.)
2. The grade levels in high school during which you participated (10, 11, 12, etc.)
3. Approximate number of hours per week and weeks per year that you spend in this activity
4. Leadership positions you held, honors you won, or awards you received relating to this activity
5. A description of the activity and your involvement, if necessary. For example, it's not necessary to describe varsity soccer. Every admissions officer will know what soccer is. However, if you list something like "Eagles for CHOC," they'll need to know that this is a "high school community service organization that works with the Children's Hospital of Orange County." Please remember to spell out acronyms; your admissions counselor might not be familiar with what "CSF" stands for.

Section II: Academic Honors and Awards

List the award name, the date received, and the description of the award. Use the description to add any special significance to the award (e.g., only one junior is chosen, 400 applicants for 10 awards, etc.). By the way, the Academic Honors and Awards section is usually the shortest for most students. Don't worry if you have only a few awards to list (or none!).



Activity List

Name of Activity/Organization & your Position/Role	9	10	11	12	Hours /Week	Weeks /Year	Description (150 character limit)
Smith High School Wind Ensemble, Alto Saxophone/Guitar	X	X	X	X	5	20	Artist/Instrumentalist in Wind Ensemble (9, 11), self-taught in the saxophone & guitar. Played the sax for 7 years and found the guitar due to my love of classic rock.
Assistance League of Tustin, Community Aid Group Volunteer			X	X	4	16	Enjoy helping at food drives. It was intimidating asking for donations, but it was worth it when I saw that I raised over 1000 pounds of food.
Best Buddies, Mentor/Volunteer	X	X	X	X	3	35	Help build students' autonomy by coaching them to dribble, shoot, and strategize at basketball games. Chaperone Prom. Develop ongoing friendships.

Activity List

Awards Received (50 character limit)	9	10	11	12	Description (150 character limit)
Student of the Month: History		X			Awarded to one outstanding student from Mr. Kyle's six history classes
Mira Costa High School Scholar Athlete Award	X	X	X		Awarded to students who maintain a 3.2 GPA while participating in sports

Admissions Interviews

To prepare for an interview, we recommend reviewing these common questions below. You don't need to have an answer rehearsed for each (in fact, you shouldn't!), but you should feel comfortable answering most of these.

Pro tip: if you're ever stuck, you can always ask, "Could we come back to that question?" (chances are, they won't come back to it).

Otherwise, remember that an interview never makes or breaks an application. In fact, there's really nothing you can do in an interview that will change an admission decision. But the best interviews can highlight what an admissions office already knows about you in your application. As long as you're honest, thoughtful, and stay away from one-word answers, you're likely to have a great interview.

Sample Questions

1. Tell me a little bit about yourself.
2. Why do you want to attend this university/college?
3. What is one of your strengths? What's something you're working on?
4. What do you want to do in the future?
5. Tell me about your interests/hobbies.
6. Tell me about your involvement in extracurricular activities.
7. What three words best describe you?
8. What are you proudest of from high school so far?
9. If you could meet any important figure in the past or present, who would it be and what would you talk about?
10. If you could be any animal, what would you be and why?
(Weird, yes, but it's been asked before.)
11. What do you want to major in? Why? What are you most interested in right now?
12. What is your favorite class in high school? Least favorite class? Why?
13. Tell me one thing you like about your high school and what, if anything, you'd like to change.
14. Looking back on your high school career, is there anything you would have done differently?
15. Tell me something about yourself that is NOT in the application.
16. What was one of your New Year's Resolutions this year (and if you didn't make any, why not)?
17. If you were introducing yourself to your roommate through a book, what book would you choose?
18. If you were to give a TED Talk, what would it be on?
19. If you had four hours to yourself, what would you do in that time?
20. If I were to write a post-it on your application folder, what would it say about you?



Questions to Ask Your Interviewer

If it's an admissions counselor:

1. Of the students who are happiest here, what qualities do they have in common?
2. What's something you wish more students knew or considered before applying to college?
3. What sort of student typically *isn't* a good fit for this school?
4. What were the last most popular events on campus?
5. If I were to walk around campus and overhear students chatting, what would they most likely be talking about?
6. What's a recent issue that's come up on campus amongst students, staff, or faculty? (If a private, religiously affiliated college) What's the most common form of religious engagement and expression, on and off campus, by students, staff, and faculty?
7. What would you change about your campus community?

If it's an alumnus:

1. What do you see now as the biggest benefit of your time there/what are you most grateful for from your time there?
2. What experiences at ____ most led you to the path you're on now?
3. What were your favorite traditions or community experiences?
4. What did you major in? Are you using that major now? Did you go on a different path from what you expected?
5. What would you say are the most common misconceptions of students and student life at ____?
6. What were the things you didn't like or enjoy about ____? How did they affect your overall experience?
7. What was your favorite class and why?

If it's a current student:

1. How would you describe your friend group? What qualities do they have in common?
2. What are the most striking differences between your expectations and your experience there?
3. What are your favorite traditions or community experiences?
4. What are you majoring in? Did it change from what you originally planned or thought you'd study? Why/how?
5. What would you change about your campus community?
6. What was your favorite class and why?
7. What else were you considering, and why did you choose ____?

Thank Your Interviewer

Plan to write a thank you note to your interviewer within a day or two, while the meeting is still fresh in your mind. In the email (yes, an email works just fine), you can reference one or two topics that came up during the interview and thank them for their time. This isn't a cover letter for a job, nor is it an essay expounding your obsession with the school. It's a simple note of gratitude, so sincerity and brevity are key.

Sample Thank You

Dear Ms. Liu:

I wanted to thank you for taking the time to speak with me about Bryn Mawr. I know this is a busy time of year for you, so I appreciate you fitting me into your schedule.

In my college search, I've realized how much traditions and an inclusive community spirit matter to me, so I really enjoyed hearing about Lantern Night and May Day in particular.

The campus community seems just what I'm looking for in a college experience.

Thank you again for your time, and I look forward to hearing from the admissions committee.

Sincerely,
Leslie Knope

College Tours

Why should I go on a college tour?

While you can do fantastic research using online resources and visiting college fairs held at your high school, it's still important to see at least a few colleges in person. If you're looking at larger universities, it can put the size of the campus and student body into perspective. If you're a born and raised city person considering a move to a rural area, it will give you a firsthand look into what the surrounding town looks like, what travel to and from the nearest city center looks like, and how the sights and activities compare to your hometown. Stepping on a school's campus or even just visiting a school with a similar environment can help you identify what kinds of schools are the right fit for you.

What kinds of notes should I take on a college tour?

Many colleges will ask essay questions about why you hope to attend their college, so taking thoughtful notes during college tours can save you time down the road AND help you remember why you loved, liked, or disliked a college when evaluating your list. Here are some questions to consider on your tour:

- What is distinctive about the college? What are they most proud of?
- What are their strongest academic programs? Do those align with your interests?
- What is the style of their curriculum?
- What features do you notice about the physical campus? For instance, is it spread out? Are there lots of new buildings and facilities?
- What do you notice about the tour guide? Are they happy at this school? Do their insights give you a sense that you could find your community at this school?
- What have you learned about the quality of life at the school? Think about things like the dorms, food, clubs, etc.
- Which extracurricular organizations align with your current extracurriculars or potential interests and passions?
- Does the surrounding town offer additional social and/or academic opportunities for students?
- What kind of career and professional advising services do they offer?
- What is the relationship between faculty and students like?
- Do your academic qualifications align with the school's profile of a typical admitted student?

Narrowing Down Your College List

Step One:

Write down each school you're considering. Next to each college, answer the following:

- Is it a reach, target, or likely school for you?
- What is the middle 50th percentile range of the SAT/ACT scores of admitted students?
- Can you apply on the Common App?
- Does the application include required or optional supplemental essays?
- What are the possible application deadlines? Which one would you likely choose?

Step Two:

Write down the three major priorities of what you're looking for in a prospective college. You can use criteria like size, location, available majors, etc. Here's an example:

- 1) A balance of academic and social experiences
- 2) An inclusive environment with lots of school traditions and a sense of community
- 3) Access to opportunities/extensive classwork in creative writing

Step Three:

Start a new document with all the potential colleges on your list and answer the following questions for each school:

- What are the elements that show this is a good fit for you?
- Does it align with any of your three priorities? If so, which one(s)?
- Name 2-3 specific things you love about the school.

College Essay Self-Assessment

- 1 Did you answer the prompt?
- 2 Are you satisfied with the opening line?
- 3 What is your favorite part of the essay?
- 4 Are there any changes that should be made to your essay?
- 5 Is the essay the right length? Is there anything that needs to be added or removed?
- 6 Which parts of the essay highlight your personality?
- 7 Do you feel you've been authentic throughout the essay?
- 8 Are there any grammatical errors in the essay?

Supplemental Essays

Q

Why do some college applications include supplemental essays?

A

Supplemental essay responses are one of the many application components that can help an admissions officer decide if you are a good fit for their university. The supplemental essay prompts allow you to provide information about a specific topic that might not otherwise be included in your application that factors into their consideration process.

Q

What's the difference between the personal statement and supplemental essays?

A

The Personal Statement tells an admission officer "Here's who I am". Supplemental essays tell an admissions officer "...And this is why you should care, [university]."



Why Us?

What is it:

The classic “why are you interested in us?” question, this is one of the most asked questions in applications (and a tricky one to do well).

1. **The open-ended question:** This is the most straightforward. They simply ask why their school, why you’re applying, or what led you to them.
2. **The leading question:** These often lead with a quote, a mission statement, or some nugget of information that tells you they’re wanting you to reflect on how you’re a fit to this element of the school.
3. **The academic + why us hybrid:** This is common at bigger universities where you’re applying to a particular college or major pathway. They want to know not just why their school, but how your academic interests match and how you’ll explore those. Make sure to lean on the “academic interests” document in writing this one as well.

SMU

SMU appeals to students for a variety of reasons. Briefly describe why you are interested in attending SMU and what specific factors have led you to apply.

250 words max

Santa Clara

Briefly describe what prompted you to apply to Santa Clara University. Based on what you know about SCU and our Jesuit mission to educate citizens and leaders of competence, conscience, and compassion, how do you envision your life at SCU and beyond?

200 words max

UMich

Describe the unique qualities that attract you to the specific undergraduate College or School (including preferred admission and dual degree programs) to which you are applying at the University of Michigan. How would that curriculum support your interests?

550 words max

Academic Interests

What is it:

This question gets to the heart of what your current interests are and how you might pursue them in college.

1. **Why major:** This is the most straightforward version. It's typical of schools where you're applying more directly into a specific major, and they want to hear how you've decided on that pathway.
2. **What do you hope to study:** This is a more open-ended version of the question above. It invites you to share multiple academic pathways, perhaps if you're undecided or see many roads ahead for yourself.
3. **Intellectual curiosity:** This is a popular question for liberal arts colleges or any college that celebrates intellectual discovery and exploration (ie, where changing your academic pathway, or exploring many interests, is easy or encouraged).

USC

Describe how you plan to pursue your academic interests and why you want to explore them at USC specifically. Please feel free to address your first- and second-choice major selections.

250 words max

Boulder

What do you hope to study, and why, at CU Boulder? Or if you don't know quite yet, think about your studies so far, extracurricular/after-school activities, jobs, volunteering, future goals, or anything else that has shaped your interests.

250 words max

Stanford

The Stanford community is deeply curious and driven to learn in and out of the classroom. Reflect on an idea or experience that makes you genuinely excited about learning.

250 words max



Identity & Community

What is it:

One of the more reflective questions, this asks you to speak to an element of who you are or where you come from, and how that might influence your future college community.

1. **Past/present community --> identity:** This is often asked as “the world you come from” or to reflect on a community you’re currently a part of and how that’s shaped your identity.
2. **Identity --> future community:** This focuses on your present identity, asking you to reflect on an element of it, and how you might bring that and impact your future college community.

UW

Our families and communities often define us and our individual worlds. Community might refer to your cultural group, extended family, religious group, neighborhood or school, sports team or club, co-workers, etc. Describe the world you come from and how you, as a product of it, might add to the diversity of the UW.

300 words max

Oregon

1. Describe an experience with discrimination, whether it was fighting against discrimination or recognizing your contribution to discriminating against a person or group. What did you learn from the experience? In what ways will you bring those lessons to the University of Oregon?
2. The University of Oregon values difference, and we take pride in our diverse community. Please explain how you will share your experiences, values and interests with our community. In what ways can you imagine offering your support to others?

500 words max

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